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Navigating the Ethical AI maze

IBM's Francesca Rossi on building AI we can all trust

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In an era where artificial intelligence is no longer the stuff of science fiction but an integral part of our daily lives, the ethical implications of AI deployments have moved from theoretical academic debates to pressing real-world concerns. As AI systems become more embedded in every aspect of our phygital lives, the question is no longer about what AI can do, but what it should be doing in a responsible manner. I had the opportunity to interview Francesca Rossi, IBM Fellow and Global Leader for AI Ethics at IBM, to delve into these complex issues.

Francesca Rossi is no stranger to the ethical quandaries posed by AI. With over 220 scientific articles under her belt and leadership roles in organisations like AAAI and the Partnership on AI, she's at the forefront of shaping how we think about AI ethics today.

ETHICAL CHALLENGES OF RAPID AI GROWTH

"AI is growing rapidly – it's being used in many services that consumers interact with today. That's why it's so important to address the ethical challenges that AI can bring up," Rossi began. She highlighted the critical need for users to trust AI systems, emphasising that trust hinges on explainability and transparency.

"For users, it's important from an ethical standpoint to be able to trust the recommendations of an AI system. Achieving this needs AI explainability and transparency," she said. But trust isn't the only concern. Rossi pointed out that data handling, privacy, and protecting copyrights are also significant ethical challenges that need to be tackled head-on.

When asked how IBM defines 'Responsible AI,' Rossi detailed a comprehensive framework that goes beyond mere principles to include practical implementations.

"IBM built a very comprehensive AI ethics framework, which includes both principles and their implementations, with the goal to guide the design, development, deployment, and use of AI inside IBM and for our clients," she explained.

The principles are straightforward yet profound:

1. The purpose of AI is to augment human intelligence.
2. Data and insights belong to their creator.
3. New technology, including AI systems, must be transparent and explainable.

But principles alone aren't enough. Rossi emphasised the importance of turning these principles into action: "The implementation of these principles includes risk assessment processes,

education and training activities, software tools, developers' playbooks, an integrated governance program, research innovation, and a centralised company-wide governance in the form of an AI ethics board."

IBM's commitment to open and transparent innovation is also evident. "We've released our family of Granite models to the open-source community under an Apache 2.0 licence for broad, unencumbered commercial usage, along with tools to monitor the model data – ensuring it's up to the standards demanded by responsible enterprise applications," Rossi added.

COLLABORATION WITH POLICYMAKERS IS KEY

The role of policymakers in AI ethics is a hot topic, and Rossi believes that collaboration between companies and governments is crucial.

"As a trusted AI leader, IBM sees a need for smart AI regulation that provides guardrails for AI uses while promoting innovation," she said. IBM is urging governments globally to focus on risk-based regulation, prioritise liability over licensing, and support open-source AI innovation.

"While there are many individual companies, start-ups, researchers, governments, and others who are committed to open science and open technol-